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Ethical Issues in Technology

A1: I chose the “healthcare provider stores data” scenario for this assignment. The main ethical issue that occurred in this scenario was that a large healthcare company failed in its obligation to protect the sensitive data of its patients. Millions of patients’ personal information had been leaked due to a wide-scale data breach, and now many individuals are worried about the possible misuse of their personal information.

A2: Unauthorized access of sensitive personal information is dangerous because once data is accessed by cybercriminals, it is virtually impossible to resecure that information. This not only affects the patients but their families as well. If personal information such as their SSN and/or home addresses were accessed by cybercriminals, it is now susceptible to being used to commit fraud or other various means that could impact a victim's safety and/or financial well-being.

A3: Based on this scenario, data security has been the main issue. Millions of victims had their personal information accessed by attackers. Because the healthcare company failed to keep patients' data secure, attackers were able to breach through the company's security systems and obtain very sensitive information of patients. If the data that was stolen was properly encrypted, the attackers would not have been able to gain access to sensitive information.

B1: For this scenario, I have chosen the deontology framework. Deontology is an ethical framework which focuses on judging actions based on the principles of right or wrong, not the outcomes. These principles stem from two major points, duties and moral obligations (Burton et al., 2023). The healthcare company had a moral obligation to make sure patients’ data was secure, but it was not able to do so because their sensitive information was already vulnerable and had not been encrypted. Based on deontology, the healthcare provider should now implement proper security procedures such as regular audits, enforced data encryption, and a dedicated cybersecurity team that will follow all these things to ensure all sensitive information/data secure. This way, the healthcare provider will be able to prevent such a catastrophic breach from happening. Under no circumstance should attackers be able to obtain this amount of sensitive information. It is the healthcare provider’s duty to ensure patients’ information is secure at all times.

B2: The second framework I have selected is utilitarianism. Utilitarianism is another ethical framework that focuses on actions that will leave the majority of people happy with the outcome (Burton et al., 2023). Using this framework during the aftermath of a data breach, the healthcare provider must ensure they are enforcing data encryption, tightening up their cybersecurity team’s

procedures, conducting regular audits, and making sure they are taking care of their patients. Since many of them were affected by this and their sensitive information was exposed, offering free credit monitoring was the right move to make because it helped patients track any unusual activity that might have occurred due to this data breach. Ultimately, both frameworks prioritize keeping patients' sensitive information safe. A utilitarian framework leans towards keeping the patients happy but does not necessarily focus on the basis of responsibility of data security. However, deontology seems to be the more structural framework to follow for this company because it places the entire responsibility on the company. It requires the healthcare provider to have systems in place that prevent a data breach prior to them happening.

References

Burton, E., Goldsmith, J., Mattei, N., Siler, C. & Swiatek, S. (2023). Computing and technology ethics: Engaging through science fiction. The MIT Press.

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